all those who advance or follow Bonn's claim to sole, representation: Socialism in the GDR is final and irrevocable, and anyone who casts doubts on our frontiers, casts doubts on his own existence!

14

In the years of his decline, Ulbricht was absorbed by improving relations with the FRG. However, off and on throughout 1967, he had been unwell. In that period, he tweaked the constitution to declare, 'The German Democratic Republic is a socialist state of the German nation. It is the political organisation of the workers in the cities and in the countryside, who jointly under the leadership of the working class and their Marxist-Leninist Party will realise Socialism.' While the old document made no mention of the SED, the new constitution unequivocally professed 'the leadership of the state is to be exercised through the working class and its Marxist-Leninist Party – the SED'.

As the winter of 1967 drew in, Honecker was invited to the Soviet Union to mark the fiftieth anniversary of the October Revolution and deliver several speeches about 'fraternal socialist cooperation'. Eager to be seen as a statesman, he took centre stage through three days of pomp and pageants. Speaking at the Novovoronezh power station, where preparatory work for the GDR's second nuclear power plant, the Atomkraftwerk Nord, was being carried out, he returned to the issue of the Berlin Wall. He spoke thoughtfully, saying until 13 August 1961, the GDR was forced to pursue socialist development under the conditions dictated by an open frontier, but 'we succeeded, with the fraternal support of the Soviet Union in making the German Democratic Republic a stable, socialist state in which the ideas of Lenin are triumphant'.15 He made sure the GDR saw his performance by arranging taped recordings to be sent back to Berlin via Interflug, enabling millions of East Germans to watch the Red Army orchestra play the GDR anthem, Auferstanden aus Ruinen, at a sumptuous gala dinner, where Honecker gave a stiff salute.